

1930–1944

CLASSICISM

In September 1930 the French magazine *L'Officiel de la Mode* observed “a tendency towards classicism and pure Greek lines” in the latest collection of the Paris fashion houses, singling out Vionnet as having been “decidedly” influenced by Greek art. In the previous decade appreciation of ancient styles had found expression in the use of patterns such as the meander or the Greek key. The return to long evening gowns in the 1930s enabled couturiers to transform their clients into Greek or Roman statues. The look of original garments from the classical period had been a matter of chance coupled with the wearer’s skill for drapery. Neoclassical gowns were more structured – the drapery and folds more controlled – drawing attention to the body underneath. The use of fluid fabrics such as silk jersey or satin, asymmetry, and decorative borders were trademarks of this new line. White and off-white governed this style, but black, and occasionally brighter colours, were also used.

MADAME GRÈS



In 1933 Germaine Krebs began to create clothes under the assumed name of Alix Barton. She changed her name again when she opened the House of Grès in Paris in 1942. Having trained as a sculptress, Mme Grès liked to drape her pleated evening gowns on a model or stand. She often used silk jersey, which moulded itself to the wearer’s body, for her neoclassical designs. Her success continued until the 1980s.

1937



Slightly trained

Alix Barton Silk or wool jersey was a favourite material of Alix Barton (later known as Madame Grès), which she used to create gowns reminiscent of Ancient Greek dress. The drapery is often held together by drawstrings, ties, or girdles.

1931

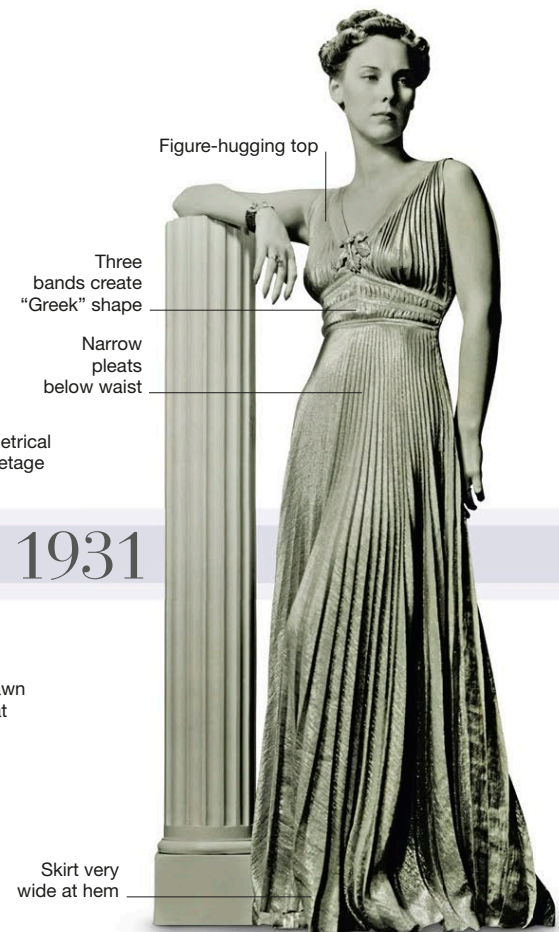


Figure-hugging top
Three bands create “Greek” shape
Narrow pleats below waist

Skirt very wide at hem

Pleating It is not surprising that dieting was much discussed in the 1930s, as evening dresses of this decade focused attention on the body while providing little support. This skirt’s width is created by narrow pleats fanning out.



Smooth top
Cape or shawl at back
Metallic leather decoration
Slim skirt

Leather accents This dress’s classical feel is created through very clean lines and the belt’s gold and silver pattern. The scrollwork is made of metallic leather, a material French designer Lanvin experimented with in the mid-1930s.